

Erasmus University Rotterdam (EUR) CoARA Action Plan (2025-2027)

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1. Introduction

Erasmus University Rotterdam (EUR) is committed to fostering an inclusive and inspiring academic environment that supports researchers and educators in achieving excellence. As part of its Strategy 2024, EUR aims to be an impact driven institution that contributes meaningfully to societal wellbeing. To realize these ambitions, the university is aligning its research assessment practices with the principles of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA). This requires a fundamental shift in how academic contributions are recognized, appreciated and rewarded, ensuring a more holistic and qualitative approach to evaluation.

This CoARA Action Plan is directly linked to and builds upon [EUR's Recognition & Rewards Framework](#), which serves as the foundation for transforming the way we assess our academic staff in hiring, evaluation and promotion procedures. By integrating the principles of Recognition & Rewards (R&R) a national programme in the Netherlands to create [room for everyone's talent](#), EUR ensures that research excellence, high-quality education, societal impact and engagement activities (including Open Science practices), and inclusive leadership are all valued appropriately.

The EUR - CoARA action plan is at the same time strongly embedded in the national research quality assurance policy that has been laid down by the Universities in the Netherlands (UNL), the Dutch Research Council (NWO), and the Royal Netherlands Academy of Arts and Sciences (KNAW). The applicable protocol for research evaluations, namely the Strategic Evaluation Protocol 2021-2027 allows for the evaluation of research achievements of faculties and research groups on the basis of their own strategic goals and targets. While qualitative data can still be used to support the narrative that is used to describe the achievements in terms of quality, impact and viability, the focus has shifted to obtaining strategic advice of the evaluation committee instead of a quantitative quality assessment.

Developed in collaboration with the Schools, Human Resources, Engagement and Research Services, and Academic Affairs, this action plan sets the stage for implementing CoARA-aligned assessment reforms at multiple levels across the university. It explicitly references the EUR Recognition & Rewards Framework to guide the transition towards qualitative, responsible, and transparent research assessment and evaluation. This plan is a living document, continuously refined through school-level implementation, ongoing evaluations, and periodic updates to ensure lasting and meaningful change in research assessment practices.

2. CoARA Commitments, Current Status and Future Plans of EUR

CoARA commitments:	Current Status (March 2025)	Plans for 2025-2027:
Recognizing the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research	• EUR's Recognition & Rewards framework differentiates career paths and acknowledges contributions beyond publications, including teaching, leadership, and societal impact related activities. • The use of narratives in evaluation and assessment procedures (like yearly development conversation and promotion procedures) have been implemented to emphasize qualitative contributions. • The EUR Open & Responsible Science program (ORS) collaborates with all the schools to support ORS activities and ORS awards are awarded yearly to both students and staff • Conversations with Schools are initiated on the importance of	• Further diversification of career paths, including horizontal career paths with an accent of (engaged) research, (engaged) education, management, or leadership. • Enhanced connection and integration of Open and Responsible Science (ORS) practices and R&R in recruitment, selection, development, and performance evaluations supported by the Open Science NL grant. • Development and implementation of Strategic Personnel Planning and the related strategic talent management plans at all Schools. • Further development and implementation of teamwork approach in which individual talents and qualities are complementary to

	teamwork. Within some schools, pilots have been set-up to actively recognise and appreciate teamwork and reward team efforts. • Training programs on diversity, leadership, and academic career development are (re)designed based on the EUR leadership profile which was launched Q4 2024. • The Evaluating Societal Impact project supports the development of an EUR wide approach for impact that is embedded in a deliberate, goal-oriented process of impact governance on all relevant levels and within all the core activities of our university (research, education and engagement). A suite of impact toolboxes is developed for all phases of academic work, including (engaged) research.	each other. • Expansion of mentorship and training for early career researchers (e.g. peer review, PhD supervisor training). • (Re)design of leadership training portfolio through the lens of R&R for academics at all levels (both formal leadership and informal leadership). • Further development of organisation wide governance structure for impact and engagement enablement, and practices to support academics in being and/or becoming engaged researchers.
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Basing research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation, for which peer review is central	• The research evaluation cycle of 6 years follows the Strategic Evaluation Protocol which is, compared to the previous Standard Evaluation Protocol (2016-2021) primarily focused on an evaluation based on a narrative, supported by quantitative • New promotion guidelines and the yearly development-conversations put and emphasis on qualitative indicators over quantitative metrics. Quantitative metrics should have a clear substantiative character. • Video's, webinars, workshops and guidelines are available for writing and reading narratives. • Peer review activities are formally recognized in career evaluations. • Training sessions for evaluato on qualitative research assessment.	• Developing and implementing training sessions for promotion/assessment committees. The set-up is developed through the lens of R&R. • Development of best practices for evaluating peer review contributions as a co-chair and piloting organisation within the CoARA working group for recognising and rewarding peer review 2024 – 2026. • Integration of peer review recognition in school evaluation frameworks.
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Abandoning inappropriate uses of journal- and publication-based metrics	• The SEP 2021-2017 only allows for the use of journal and publication-based metrics as support information to the narrative (the self-study report). • It is actively discouraged to use JIF and h-index in individual hiring, promotion, and funding decisions. • Engagement & Research Services provides training and policies on responsible use of research metrics such as San Francisco DORA, CoARA, Leiden Manifesto and INORMS' SCOPE framework.	• Review existing licenses and selecting those that align with this new approach to research assessment, including the use of commercial products (e.g. Elsevier and Clarivate Analytics) and its capabilities for incorporating alternative metrics and diverse research outputs. • Continued communication and training to reinforce qualitative assessment. • Development of alternative impact indicators for both research and education in collaboration with our Schools, national and international partners.
Avoiding the use of institutional rankings in research assessment	• EUR discourages the use of global rankings in research assessment as this is not in line with the national evaluation protocol SEP 2021-2027. Schools use rankings for marketing purposes only.	• Strengthening internal assessment frameworks aligned with CoARA principles. • Raising awareness among stakeholders about the limitations of institutional rankings and support them in how to

		communicate correctly about rankings.
Allocating resources to reform research assessment	• Use of an advisory committee on R&R consisting of senior academics of all Schools and directors of professional service departments. • Dedicated programme team within the broader organisation to encourage, facilitate and support the development and implementation of R&R. Strong collaboration with ERS and HR exists. Multiple teams and partners work closely with all the EUR Schools. • EUR Schools are encouraged to allocate resources for career diversification initiatives. Within many Schools duo's/trios (HR Business Partner/Policy Advisor/Academic) were initiated to actively work on the implementation of	• Continuously investing in knowledge and expertise on R&R, ORS, qualitative assessments, and alternative metrics and how to implement these in running business. • Increased funding for initiatives supporting alternative career paths. • Collaboration with external funding agencies to align grant assessment with CoARA commitments.

	R&R at the School level.	
Reviewing and developing research assessment criteria, tools, and processes	• EUR has adopted new CV formats focusing on narratives. • Open Science and Societal Impact activities are more and more embedded in research evaluations.	• Regular reviews and evaluation of assessment criteria at the School and organisation level (e.g. awards, young academy etc.) to ensure alignment with CoARA. • Development of qualitative methodologies for research evaluation using in-house expertise, data scientists and internal data. This includes portfolio, policy, and social media analysis with machine learning and semantic search. Due to data sensitivity, results are not publicly shared, and commercial databases are not used.
Raising awareness and providing transparent communication, guidance, and training	• Information sessions and workshops for faculty and staff and- for example- narrative writing and reading.	• Utilise existing national RRview platform for sharing best practices and resources. EUR will work on updating our own website which

	• Integration of R&R in several events targeting academic staff. In these events, progress of the development and implementation is presented as are local, national and international good practices and developments.	will also include an R&R toolbox and links to other important developments locally or outside the organisation. • Expansion of training programs on alternative metrics and peer review recognition.
Exchanging practices and experiences to enable mutual learning	• Active participation in CoARA working group, EUR is a co-chair of Recognising and Rewarding Peer Review • Collaboration with Dutch universities and funding bodies on R&R initiatives. • Interaction with international (research) institutes to exchange knowledge, experience and learnings on modernising the system for research evaluation/assessment	• Further strengthening international partnerships for mutual learning. • Hosting an (collaborative) annual symposium on research assessment reforms. Collaborators can include -but are not limited to- colleagues working on the topics of Impact & Engagement, Open & Responsible Science, Recognition & Rewards
Communicating progress on adherence to CoARA principles	• Intranet and newsletters provide updates on R&R	• Administrative agreements between Executive Board and Schools on R&R implementation to

	initiatives and developments. • Regular reporting on progress to EUR leadership and CoARA.	monitor implementation milestones. • Establishing open consultation sessions for faculty feedback.
Evaluating research assessment practices based on evidence and research-on-research insights and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research	• Research Intelligence has developed novel applications and use of alternative impact indicators and responsible metrics for evaluating societal impact and interdisciplinarity. These include Portfolio analyses, policy and social media analyses.	• Systematic data collection on the effects of R&R policies. • Collaboration with research-on-research initiatives to refine best practices.

3. Conclusion

EUR is dedicated to driving the transformation of research assessment and evaluation in alignment with the CoARA commitments. This action plan represents a significant step towards fostering a fair, transparent, and inclusive evaluation system that recognizes and values the diverse contributions of our academic community across research, education, leadership, and societal engagement.

Building on our R&R framework, EUR has already introduced differentiated career tracks and integrated narrative CVs into assessments, enabling a broader and more meaningful evaluation of academic activities and achievements. Moving forward, we will expand horizontal career paths, further embed Open and Responsible Science practices, and implement strategic talent management plans across all schools. These initiatives will ensure that research excellence is not narrowly defined by publication metrics but is instead assessed holistically, incorporating qualitative indicators and peer review contributions.

As co-chair of the CoARA Working Group on Recognising and Rewarding Peer Review (2024-2026), EUR has a pivotal role in shaping international best practices. We recognize that shifting

research assessment from an outcome-driven exercise to a process-oriented evaluation system requires time, infrastructure, and capacity for innovation and experimentation. Successfully embedding peer review at the core of assessment processes will necessitate the formal recognition of peer review contributions and the development of comprehensive training programs to equip evaluators with the necessary skills for qualitative assessment. By investing in these efforts, EUR aims to become a leading institution in the global movement towards responsible research assessment.

Our commitment to reform is reinforced through active participation in the Dutch Recognition & Rewards program, where we continuously exchange best practices, experiences, and lessons learned with national partners. Furthermore, EUR remains engaged in the broader international research policy landscape, contributing to key discussions at forums such as the World Science Forum and other global knowledge platforms.

Ultimately, research assessment reform is not a one-time intervention but an ongoing cultural and systemic transformation. By embedding collaboration, innovation, and inclusivity at the heart of our policies, EUR is committed to driving sustainable change in how research is valued and evaluated, both within and outside of our institution.